

KF48 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We have the opportunity to rebuild our foundations with KF Confession 11:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

Training to be still and silent in body and mind lays foundation that we need for our growth. We can apply this skill when we feel frustrated, compelled, or anxious, and when we or others make mistakes. In KF we are learning to spend more time observing and less time talking. This is one of the reasons that we adhere to time restraints in our sharing. When we share moderately and efficiently, we exercise restraint and show respect for our listeners.

Meditation helps us learn to dwell without words. In his vision, the Apostle John witnessed a worship ceremony in heaven that included thirty minutes of silence.¹ Silence during worship today would drive most Christians crazy! As we learn to be silent, we no longer use words to suppress our anxiety or to keep God at a comfortable distance. Silent minds let go of words, images, or sensations and come to the place of pure connection with God. This might be the connection that Paul talks about in First Corinthians: “Now we see through a mirror of riddles, but then we will see face to face.”² When our minds learn to dwell without words, we come face to face with God.

In this lesson, we will revisit **Centering Prayer**³ while practicing the **Sunlight Meditation**. Take the meditation posture. Lift the top of your head so that your neck is somewhat straightened. Lower your chin a little and let your shoulders fall back. Gently close your eyes and keep them closed throughout this meditation. Allow your body to regulate your breathing as you begin one minute of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now, let go of **Alternate Nostril Breathing** and move to **Centering Prayer**. Allow a centering word, which may be a phrase, a word, or an image, to float to the surface of your mind. *(Pause for 5 seconds)* As you breathe, bring your word to mind, then let it go and rest in the stillness. If your mind wanders, use the word and your breath to re-collect yourself. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, gently lift your eyes toward the middle of your forehead and feel a slight stretch in your eye muscles. You might find it helpful to imagine that you are looking at the inside of your forehead. Breathe. If you need to recall your mind, use your word. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Imagine that the sun or a lamp is shining into your eyes. *(Pause)* Imagine what the light and heat would feel like on your forehead. Breathe. Practice dwelling silently in the light for two minutes. Use your word to recall your mind. *(Pause for 2 minutes, announcing when one minute has passed)*

Pause. Take a deep breath, and stretch. Gently open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting.

Our hymn of gratitude and mercy is *Great is Thy Faithfulness*.

Pardon for sin and a peace that endureth,
Thine own dear presence to cheer and to guide;
Strength for today and bright hope for tomorrow,
Blessings all mine, with ten thousand beside!⁴

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 11 helps us learn new habits:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

Last week we explored SET—S-E-T—which stands for Support, Empathy, and Truth. These three steps will help you communicate more effectively with others.⁵ Each Idol type struggles with at least one area of SET. Mastery types resist supporting others. Resigned types suppress any effort toward empathy. Self-effacing types wish to avoid telling the truth.

It takes regular effort and intention to develop the habit of SET. Just knowing what SET means does not make you adept at this skill. You might practice this technique and ask for feedback when you interact with trustworthy people. You will then be trained to use this tool in sensitive situations. Your practice is most valuable when you or other people are upset and in the throes of emotion. When you find yourself in that situation, you will want to have your tool sharpened and ready to do its job.

In your early KF training, you learned how to take responsibility for the damage you have done to yourself. This damage can be physical, mental, emotional, or spiritual and is often the result of self-hate. In addition, you carry inherited debt, or damage, from others, and what you do with that debt is also your responsibility. Now that you have begun your journey of discovery and have some tools to facilitate your own healing, you can take responsibility for dealing with the damage done to you by others. Whatever that damage might be, you can thrive within your design and your present limitations. You can learn from the woman with the hemorrhage, and you can also take Dr. Horney’s advice, which is to get all the help you can. Get all the help you can as you continue to train for your opportunity to touch Jesus.

I hope that by now you have come to understand that all misorientation causes damage. In misorientation you step out of harmony with God and the Creation, and by willfully using your unique power and authority to serve the Idol, you injure God's design and obstruct His purposes. You know this, and that is why you are working hard to free yourself from misorientation. As you become more oriented, you will begin to see how your marvelous power can be used to help orient your community. Even when you have not actively participated in damaging the community, you can be an agent of healing and change. You can learn to take active responsibility for guiding others toward orientation by being careful and mindful about how you live your life. The positive results in your community will encourage you to keep pursuing the path of your own orientation. Who knows what might be possible? This vision of hope and influence widens your horizon as you boldly explore territory that you, and perhaps others, have never seen before.

Our example is Jesus, the progenitor of our faith. He never did any damage to anyone and yet He continually worked to restore damage. He paid for debts that were not His own. Although He was not actively trying to restore everyone and everything all the time, the quality of His life gave everyone He met the opportunity to restore and be restored. We are His ambassadors, and He calls each of us to participate in the same adventure.⁶

I used to think that I was called to restore everyone and everything all of the time. It was a terrific burden, and I used that story as an excuse to avoid my own development. I did not understand that my own restoration and development were my first priority. You cannot restore the Creation without first restoring yourself. Restoring yourself takes time and resources, and depending on how much damage has been done, you might find that in the first months, or even years, of KF training you will need to invest most of your resources in your own healing. As you change, your relationships will change. Some of those relationships will be challenged, but as you live as your True Self, your trustworthy relationships will grow stronger and will support you in your efforts to restore the wider community.

God wants everyone to have an abundant life, and by living a real life, you can co-labor with Him to make His desire a reality in this material world.⁷ Real lives reveal God's goodness in all the ups and downs of life—when the tide comes in and when the tide goes out. As you live your life fully engaged with reality, you can work with God to help others live abundantly, whether in your workplace, your church, your school, your neighborhood, or wherever God and your training lead you. Helping others is not meant to be a one-way street; when you help the community to live abundantly, abundance circulates back to you. There are as many ways to influence a community and circulate gifts as there are people. You might clean houses, manage employees, or work as a volunteer. You might be designed to lead a large community, perhaps as a politician or a pastor. If you are a parent, you have the potential to exert far-reaching influence by teaching your children to circulate within the family. Circulating children become circulating adults who are complete, mature, and fully equipped to change the world.

If you are tearing down or stealing from others, you are participating in damage and harming yourself. If, however, you are contributing to the MATH—the money, abilities, time, and health—of your community, you are helping your community to live abundantly, and by helping your community to live abundantly, you are helping yourself. You might be working in a job that is dishonest, poisonous, or greed-driven and drains the resources of the community, but you can fight the good fight to change that culture. You become an agent of positive change not through judgment and hostility but by working hard to live a holy life and cheerfully refusing to participate in evil. Now that you have worked hard on your orientation, you will want to protect it. So, cheerfully refuse to participate in evil.⁸

You can't learn to live a holy life overnight. You need time and training. Schedule some time to ponder, to

pray, to plan, and to peregrinate. That last word simply means to walk around observing what is there. Use A-S-K—Ask, Seek, and Knock—and see what happens.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Captain of the hosts, I want to be ready for the mission of abundance. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 11 helps restore our courage and confidence:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

In Romans chapter 12, Paul teaches us how to restore and support the Christian community. He gives us further guidance in chapter 13, so you might like to read both chapters together. Taking responsibility for damage that we have done is a great gift to those we have damaged and, also, to ourselves—and when we co-labor with God to restore damage that we did not actively cause, we give an even greater gift. This greater gift flows out of the growing wealth of Christ within us. In Karis Fellowships, we are participating in each other’s healing and restoration, and through that effort we are helping God heal the world.

This is my translation of the last verse of chapter 12.

Do not allow yourselves to be conquered by injury; rather, conquer injury by living in active good.⁹ (Repeat)

Now let’s put this verse in its context and see what Paul means when he tells us to conquer the power of injury with active good. Here is my translation of **Romans 12:17–21**.

¹⁷Never render harm in return for harm. Consider in advance what would be a virtuous response in the eyes of all people. ¹⁸If it is possible, be peaceable with everyone through accessing the resources of your own inner peace. ¹⁹You who are blessed with God’s love, do not punish anyone, but leave a place for God’s wrath, for it is written: “Punishment is Mine”, says the Lord. “I, Myself, will pay it back.”¹⁰ ²⁰Instead, “when someone who hates you is hungry, supply them with bits of something to eat; if thirsty, furnish them with drink. For when you do this, you heap burning coals upon their head.”¹¹ ²¹Do not allow yourselves to be conquered by injury; rather, conquer injury by choosing active good.

Take a deep breath.

Paul’s imperative to “conquer injury by choosing active good” summarizes what he is teaching us in this passage.

Let’s look at four points that we can learn from his teaching.

1. Violated legal systems

In this passage, Paul reminds us that our constant temptation is to react in a misoriented way to whatever we perceive as injury or harm. When events or people violate our claims and hurt our pride, our perceptions become distorted, and we judge that violation and hurt as personal injury. This sense of injury drives us to take the judgment path, which leads to retaliation and blame, and we end up hurting both ourselves and others. We are conquered by evil. We see only the injury and are blind to the possibility, or reality, of any good. In our misorientation, we step out of our business and try to take over another's or God's business. We become the willing slave of injury and create more injury.

2. Circulate goodness

As the people of God, even when we are damaged by another person's choices and actions, we do not retaliate by returning evil for evil or harm for harm. Paying back is simply a means of defending our pride system. Paul is not telling us to be doormats, however; He is encouraging us to circulate active goodness for our own sake.

3. Consider in advance

KF training prepares us to respond to every situation in an oriented way and helps us put into practice Paul's injunction to consider in advance what would be a virtuous response. Let's get real. Injury from others is a fact of life. How will you choose to handle it? If you are living in active orientation, you will be able to recognize and then transcend violations of your legal system and injuries to your pride. The resources that you have been wasting in pride protection can then be redirected toward the creative management of real assault from others. When we stop carrying loads of injury based on hurt pride, we can endure real or perceived injury long enough to consider in advance how we might respond without indulging a desire for vindictive triumph. Our business is to work at developing our inner peace so that, whenever possible, we can find a way of living in peace with others. At the very least, we can withdraw or set boundaries with compassion, recognizing that when someone injures us, they are acting out of their own self-hate.

4. Protect yourself

Sometimes another person's self-hate is so extreme that you will need to protect yourself from that person. Proverbs 22:3 and 27:12 teach us to foresee injury and take steps to protect ourselves. Most people are addicted to anxious fears, rage, chaos, and drama, all of which cause injury, and the media encourages and exploits that addiction. Wise people, however, have learned through experience how to seek peace and protect themselves in an oriented way. They are able to consider in advance what might be a virtuous response in difficult situations.¹² Seek counsel and support. Learn to prepare yourself with orientation and protect yourself with goodness before you find yourself conquered by injury.

Someone once asked me if taking action to distance her children from an abusive family member might be an expression of vindictive triumph. The very fact that she asked the question told me that she did not want to act out of retaliation. She had already paused, observed, and was considering in advance what she needed to do. She was not reacting to injury; instead, she was foreseeing future injury and hiding herself and her children.

Some years ago, I realized that I could not maintain a peaceful life if I continued in a certain friendship. For nearly a year, my friend had been mindlessly blaming others for the wildfires of chaotic outcomes that she herself created. When this friend finally dropped the relationship, I was able to let her go but regretted that I had not confronted the problems in the friendship sooner. My self-effacing neurosis had imposed

taboos that blocked my ability to be honest and care for myself. I compulsively showed my friend empathy and support but could not choose the active good of sticking to my own business, courageously defending my boundaries, and moderately sharing my reality. This active good might have helped my friend avoid further injury to herself or others. Instead, my friend was conquered by both imagined and real injuries and became the arsonist of her own wildfires. I spent months chasing this friend around with a bucket of water while she ran around with a torch. Misorientation in the service of my Idol undermined my ability to foresee the evil and protect myself.

When the Idol feels injured, its first response is to retaliate out of self-hate. Allowing yourself to be mastered by self-hate will start fires, but you are learning to consider in advance how to protect yourself and respond to every injury, whether real or imagined with orientation. Do not allow injury to conquer and enslave you, forcing you to retaliate, manipulate, or retreat. Rather, conquer the injury by choosing active good.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Prince of Peace, help me conquer injury with active good. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water, and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an uncomfortable situation in your community. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you consider *an uncomfortable situation in your community*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. Accept with compassion that your pride might be hurt. Just observe your experience as you *consider this uncomfortable situation*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry, what is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this uncomfortable situation in your community*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what obsessing, frustration, or passive aggression feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this uncomfortable situation in your community*. Do you judge the situation as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—perhaps of hurt pride or self-hate? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore how you can be more trustworthy in your community.
- Welcome the gentle Holy Spirit of truth, who works toward peace.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself in your community. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹³

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I help heal my community, I let go of the longing for power and control.
- As I help heal my community, I let go of the longing for care and admiration.
- As I help heal my community, I let go of the longing for safety and survival.
- Welcome what your community is teaching you about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for drawing us together for healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us toward our real glory and authority. Set us free with the truth about our lives as You lead us to the next step in our healing. Help us co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to become more trustworthy for our own sake, for the sake of the community, and for Your sake so that the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus may be seen in this world. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

The next Karis Fellowships training cycle begins in March. KF Admin requests that all current members register now on the website for the next KF cycle to make the registration tasks easier.

¹ Rev. 8:1.

² 1 Cor.13:12.

³ www.centeringprayer.com.

⁴ *Great is Thy Faithfulness* by Thomas Chisholm (1866–1960), www.youtube.com/watch?v=dTKlqmdfHSk.

⁵ www.chrisakins.com/communicating-effectively-in-difficult-situations/.

⁶ 2 Cor. 5:20.

⁷ Matt. 6:10.

⁸ Rom. 12:21.

⁹ Rom. 12:21 in Nancy's translation.

¹⁰ Deut. 32:35.

¹¹ Prov. 25:21–22.

¹² Rom. 12:17.

¹³ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.